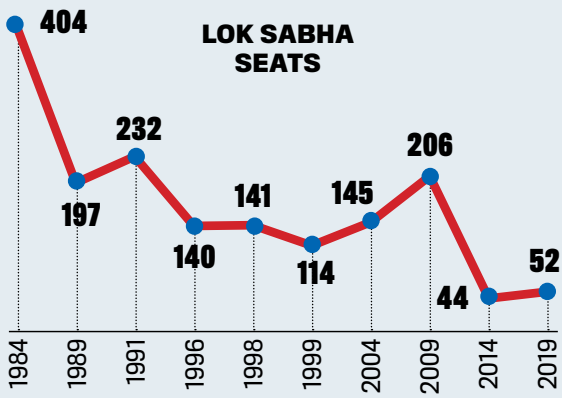
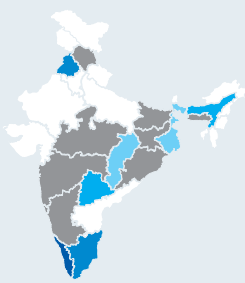


HOW THE CONGRESS HAS SHRUNK

Before 2014, the Congress tally had never fallen below 100 seats





BREAK-UP OF THE 2019 TALLY

Kerala: **15**; Tamil Nadu: **8**

Punjab: **8**; Assam: **3**; Telangana: **3**; Chhattisgarh: **2**; West Bengal: **2**

Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh, Meghalaya, Goa, Andaman & Nicobar, Himachal Pradesh (won later in a bypoll), Karnataka, Odisha, Puducherry: **1 each**

Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

THEIR DECISIONS MAY BE COLLECTIVE, BUT THE THREE GANDHIS HAVE A MIND AND FUNCTIONING STYLE OF THEIR OWN, SENDING MIXED SIGNALS WITHIN THE PARTY

challenge in the case of the Congress."

It is these five key areas that the Congress must fix at its Udaipur conclave. But no one knows better than Tewari that it is an exercise in futility. He was part of the so-called G-23 or group of 23 veteran Congress leaders who dared to challenge the game of musical chairs being played by the three Gandhis—Sonia, Rahul and Priyanka—over the party leadership in August 2020. They had demanded that the party appoint "accountable and available" leaders who could reinvigorate the organisation. But being past masters in delaying, diluting and destroying any opposition within, the Congress high command (read the Gandhis) won over most of the dissidents by giving them positions in major advisory committees. They even agreed to hold elections to the post of party president within a year, but then postponed the exercise to September 2022, citing Covid and assembly elections. The party seems inured to the enormous electoral setbacks, refusing to bring about radical change even while being aware that each election lost is one more nail in its coffin. Even poll strategist Prashant Kishor, who made an impassioned presentation to the top Congress leadership recently, decided against joining the party partly because it was reluctant to revamp its working style.

The known knowns

Much of the Congress party's ills are 'known knowns'. For instance, when one points out how Kishor in his presentation said that in the 2019 general election, the Congress fielded candidates who had lost twice consecutively in 170 Lok Sabha constituencies, veteran Congress leader and former Union home and finance minister P. Chidambaram said, "I'm sure this data is available somewhere in some files in some cupboard in the Congress party. Had we put together that data and analysed it, we would not have fielded those 170 candidates."

Likewise, Kishor's suggestion that the Congress fix the "coalition conundrum" and strategically align with other parties, playing second fiddle in regions where another non-BJP party was strong, is something the Congress could have implemented in West Bengal in the 2021